cent, it has outstripped the country's GDP growth rate of 7.2 per cent. "Our CM spearheaded advances in various sectors, which has contributed to the growth of the primary sector and the rural economy," says T. Harish Rao, the finance and health minister.

Despite Telangana's impressive strides, KCR's two-term incumbency poses many challenges for the ruling BRS. Sluggish implementation mars several welfare schemes, with allegations of public representatives seeking commissions, even in the allocation of 2BHK apartments or the Dalit Bandhu grant that offers Rs 10 lakh to Dalit families to start up a business. The rival Congress and BJP accuse the CM's family of amassing enormous wealth through widespread corruption in infrastructure projects such as the massive Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Scheme.

In a strategic move aimed at preempting disgruntlement, KCR seized the first-mover advantage by unveiling his party's candidate list for all but four of the 119 constituencies as early as August 21. The BRS retained a majority of the sitting MLAs from among the 88 elected on the pink party ticket in 2018. KCR had also succeeded in persuading several of the 19 MLAs from the Congress—which finished second—to cross party lines. Furthermore, he managed to woo many from the Telugu Desam Party, reinforcing his party's strength to a formidable 104. The early candidate announcement was targeted at forestalling potential rebel trouble, although it didn't prevent some like MLA M. Hanumantha Rao, who turned down the BRS ticket as KCR didn't offer one for his son, from switching allegiance to the Congress.

Another issue is the inadequate representation of the Other Backward Classes (OBCs) among the BRS candidates. Notably, there are at least 39 candidates from the influential Reddy community, which constitutes about 7 per cent of the state's population. In contrast, with 24 candidates, the representation of the OBCs is merely 20 per cent, despite comprising 52 per cent of the population. "There is dissatisfaction among the OBCs with the BRS for the disproportionate distribution of tickets. If the Congress and BJP take care of this, there could be a significant shift of the OBC vote share, posing problems for the BRS," says E. Venkatesu of the department of political science, University of Hyderabad.

Currently, KCR seems to have the upper hand as both the Congress and BJP were yet to finalise their tickets. Following the Congress's victory in the Karnataka assembly election, there is a growing perception that the face-off will largely be between the BRS and a resurgent Congress, with the BJP way behind, despite its combativeness, due to its lack of robust village-level committees. Surveys and opinion polls commissioned by KCR also highlight this, with the BRS consistently focusing on targeting the Congress.

KCR is determined to pull out all the stops. BJP MLA Eatala Rajender, who previously served as KCR's minister of finance and health, accuses the CM of lavish campaign spend-



BOLSTERING STRENGTH
Telangana Congress chief A. Revanth Reddy welcomes leaders from rival parties

ANI

THE CM'S REPORT CARD

STRENGTHS

- Focused charismatic leadership
- Organised party structure
- Meticulous planning
- Implemented a raft of welfare schemes
- Copious financial resources
- Contestants named early

CHALLENGES

- At least half the BRS MLAs face severe anti-incumbency
- Incomplete projects such as land distribution, housing for the poor and lack of job opportunities
- A resurgent Congress
- Change in party name to BRS blunts the pro-Telangana identity
- Inadequate OBC representation